TEAM CLEVELAND

What might economic development entities in Cleveland learn from Gen Z to inform workforce development?

A youth-voice look at Cleveland's talent gap, prepared for the partners, employers, and community who shapes it.

MOREHEAD-CAIN • CIVIC COLLABORATION • SUMMER 2026

WHERE WE'RE HEADED

Agenda

01 The Dilemma & Our Approach

02 Employment Landscape

03 The Evidence

04 Our Suggestions

05 The Bottom Line

06 Open Discussion

TEAM CLEVELAND

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SECTION 01

01

SECTION 01

The Dilemma & Our Approach

Flipping the talent-gap question to the youth side.

THE DILEMMA

The Question We Set Out to Answer

"What might economic development entities in Cleveland learn from Gen Z to inform workforce development?"

WHY IT MATTERS

Most talent-gap research is told from the employer's side.
Little of it asks the young worker why these fields struggle to recruit.
Their answers reshape how employers recruit and retain.

OUR APPROACH

How We Did the Research

30+

REACH

Community partners, civic leaders, funders, nonprofit organizations, educators, and funders complemented by participation in the Urban Agenda PolicyBridge Conference and attendance of the Workforce Summit

8

RIGOR

Worksite and orientation visits including MAGNET, Food Strong, Young Money Mentors, Arts in Motion, Lead Safe, Hyland

100+

VOICE

Youth discussions with students in academies, internship programs, and community recreation centers

02

SECTION 02

Employment Landscape

Ten barriers, outlined one at a time.

EMPLOYMENT LANDSCAPE

Ten Barriers Shape the Youth Employment Gap

Everything we heard, sorted into ten recurring barriers.

1	Job Exposure
2	Middle Management
3	Awareness of Resources
4	Non-profit Ecosystem
5	Poverty Line & Welfare
6	Public Schools
7	Support System
8	Soft Skill
9	Youth Values
10	Social Determinants of Work

01 Job Exposure

You cannot aspire to a career you have never seen.

Many youth hold a narrow picture of work, shaped by their neighborhood.
Stereotypes about which fields are "for them" narrow it further.
Site visits and real conversations beat automated placements.

> "This summer job made me really interested in a field I didn't even know about before starting."
>
> *-A rising 11th grader about their summer job*

EMPLOYMENT LANDSCAPE · 2 OF 10

02 Middle Management

Local job ladders are missing their middle rungs.

Many job openings cluster at the ends: entry-level and senior, little between. The next step up often demands expensive credentials. This is a more difficult barrier for any single program to fix than the others.

THE AGE RANGE

18–29

Cleveland youth work at high rates, yet earn below the national metro wage in low-ladder jobs (Policy Matters Ohio).

03 Awareness of Resources

The resources exist. Young people need to be aware of them.

Most youth first hear about Y.O.U. and other opportunities through family, not school, so students whose families aren't already connected have greater find their way in.

The loss is silent: scholarships go unclaimed and seats sit empty because the youth who'd benefit never knew to apply.

LOW-COST CHANNELS

- **Outreach during P.A.C.E. school visits**
- **Youth-centered social media**

04 Non-Profit Ecosystem

Cleveland’s surplus of organizations is part of the problem.

The non-profit sector is vast and confusing causing difficulty for youth seeking resources.

Overlapping programs operate in isolation, duplicating intake and training.

A young person can finish one program and still hit a dead end.

> “There's a lot of noise that reduces efficiency.”
>
> A Cleveland funder. Child Trends found shared mission beats shared space.

05 Poverty Line & Welfare

Near the poverty line, the safety net can work against mobility.

The “benefits cliff”: a raise can cost more than it adds.

The Atlanta Fed finds cliffs can make a promotion not worth taking.

ON A $1,000 RAISE

–$4,600

In one Ohio example, a $1,000 raise cost a single parent about $4,600 in food, housing, and childcare benefits.

EMPLOYMENT LANDSCAPE · 6 OF 10

06 Public Schools

Schools are meant to teach exposure and guidance, and they're under strain.

CMSD consolidation. Graduation has hovered near 70–75%; proficiency lags the state. Counselor caseloads run far past the 250-to-1 ratio.

2024 REPORT CARD

3★

In 2024, CMSD met state standards for the first time in its history, signifying a real step forward.

07 Support System

One reliable adult often separates opportunity from disengagement.

Employers and staff named mentors and job coaches as decisive.

Access is uneven, too often dependent on informal networks.

The gap isn't willing adults, but consistent structure.

FROM CHANCE TO STRUCTURE

Mentors & job coaches
A consistent, intentional program
Guidance made accessible to all

EMPLOYMENT LANDSCAPE · 8 OF 10

08 Soft Skills

The top preparation gap wasn't technical skill, it was workplace fluency.

Communication, punctuality, and unwritten norms are assumed, not taught.

Capable young workers navigate them by trial and error.

It reflects a lack of practice, not ability.

OFTEN ASSUMED, RARELY TAUGHT

Professional communication
Punctuality & reliability
Unwritten workplace norms

09 Youth Values

What employers call a “ talent gap” is often a shift in expectations.

Gen Z weighs flexibility, meaning, growth, and balance.

Not less commitment, changed expectations.

Adjustments to a new generation joining the workforce is nothing new.

ONE TOP PRIORITY: FLEXIBILITY

#1

Local high-school seniors named flexibility their top priority in a future workplace.

10 Social Determinants of Work

BARRIERS THAT STACK AT THE DOOR

Childcare, transport, housing, digital access, training, legal support, and flexibility.

Nothing else lands until these are met (Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs).

Alignment on the challenges employees face with working creates a comforting environment from day one.

THE COST AT THE DOOR · CLEVELAND

CHILDCARE & BASIC NEEDS

41% of Cuyahoga County households can't consistently afford basic necessities, including childcare

DIGITAL DIVIDE

25k Cleveland homes still without any broadband subscription as of 2023

GENERATIONAL POVERTY

60% of under-25 households fall below the affordability threshold, the highest of any age group

Sources: United Way of Greater Cleveland ALICE report; 2023 broadband estimate.

03

SECTION 03

The Evidence - What We Learned from Gen Z

From the youth's own voice.

GEN Z'S TOP PRIORITIES

1.Career Growth Opportunities
2.Work Environment and Culture
3.Pay and Benefits
4.Work-Life Balance
5.Stability

The question that guided us: “What would make a job worth staying in?”

How Gen Z Sees the Workforce Ecosystem

- 93% of those who've worked were never let go; they're reliable and loyal when given the chance.
- 47.5% rate themselves maximally motivated (5/5), and 55% are actively job-hunting right now.
- 77% say getting a job is hard; top barriers: no experience, transportation, scheduling.

GEN Z'S SELF-REPORTED STRENGTHS

- Communication
- Adaptability
- Teamwork
- Problem Solving

EMPLOYER REPORTED WEAKNESSES OF GEN Z

- Communication
- Teamwork
- Workplace etiquette
- Work Ethic

04

SECTION 04

Our Suggestions

Three system-level moves.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Three System-Level Moves

01

Anchor: A Mentorship Platform

A dashboard connecting 11th and 12th graders to paid mentors.

Barriers Addressed: Soft Skills, Awareness of Resources, and Support System

02

Microtransit

A shuttle model for the #1 named barrier.

Barriers Addressed: Social Determinants of Work

03

First Shift

A "Glassdoor" for first jobs, built by the workers who had them.

Barriers Addressed: Awareness of Resources and Youth Values

SUGGESTIONS · 1 OF 3

Anchor: A Mentorship Platform

BACKGROUND

Business and community members mentor 11th and 12th graders monthly.

HOW IT WORKS

A manager coordinates; mentees submit questions between meetings.

Anchor Platform is optional for mentors, expected of mentees, with an inactivity purge.

A short trial lets mentees continue, switch, or exit.

DELIVERABLE

A mentor & mentee dashboard.

Open the live demo →

TANGIBLE ROIs

Number of meetings held •
Before-and-after surveys

SUGGESTIONS · 2 OF 3

Microtransit Systems

WHAT IT IS

Shuttles closing the gap between bus lines and where the jobs actually are.

HOW IT WORKS

Map job and manufacturing hubs against where people live.

Cut redundant routes; keep everyone within a mile of a stop.

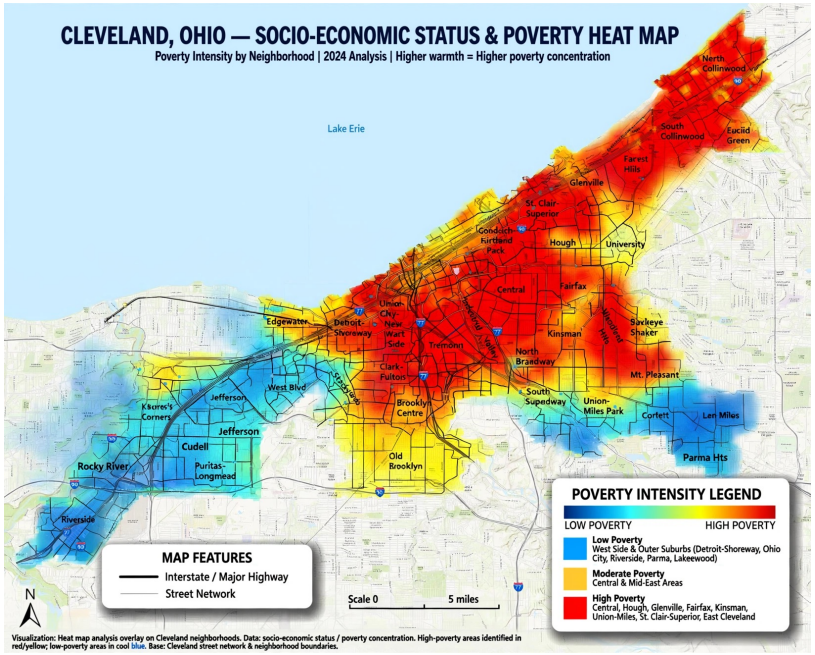
Resolve driver and funding questions.

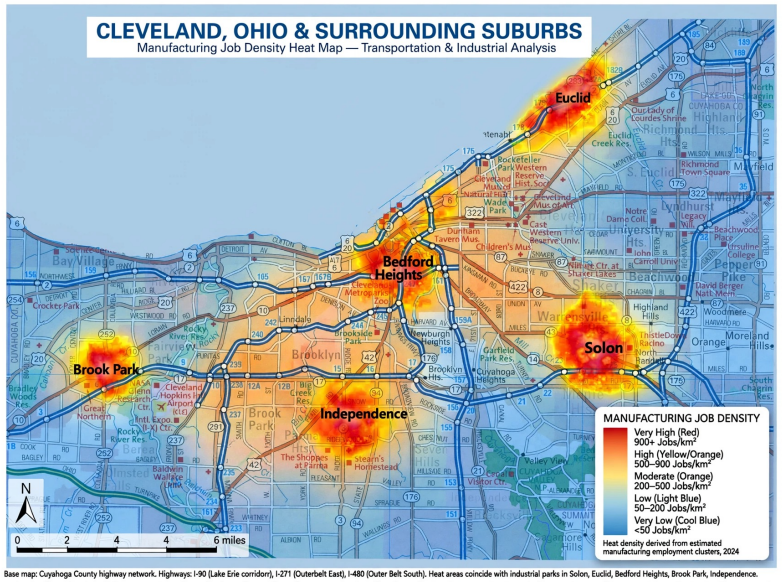
DELIVERABLE

An optimal-route shuttle model.

OPEN QUESTIONS

Who drives, and how it's funded
How many shuttles to start


CLEVELAND, OHIO — SOCIO-ECONOMIC STATUS & POVERTY HEAT MAP
Poverty Intensity by Neighborhood | 2024 Analysis | Higher warmth = Higher poverty concentration
Lake Erie
North Collinwood
South Collinwood
Euclid Green
Farrest Hills
Glenville
St. Clair-Superior
Goodrich-Kirtland Park
Hough
University
Central
Fairfax
Union-CV-Nor Wart Side
Edgewater
Detroit-Shoreway
Tremont
Kinsman
Woodland Hills
Sowkeye Shaker
North Broadway
Clark-Fulton
Mt. Pleasant
West Blvd
Jefferson
Kamm's Corners
Brooklyn Centre
South Superway
Union-Miles Park
Corlett
Lee Miles
Parma Hts
Cudell
Old Brooklyn
Rocky River
Puritas-Longmead
Riverside
MAP FEATURES
Interstate / Major Highway
Street Network
N
Scale 0
5 miles
POVERTY INTENSITY LEGEND
LOW POVERTY
HIGH POVERTY
Low Poverty
West Side & Outer Suburbs (Detroit-Shoreway, Ohio City, Riverside, Parma, Lakewood)
Moderate Poverty
Central & Mid-East Areas
High Poverty
Central, Hough, Glenville, Fairfax, Kinsman, Union-Miles, St. Clair-Superior, East Cleveland
Visualization: Heat map analysis overlay on Cleveland neighborhoods. Data: socio-economic status / poverty concentration. High-poverty areas identified in red/yellow; low-poverty areas in cool blue. Base: Cleveland street network & neighborhood boundaries.


CLEVELAND, OHIO & SURROUNDING SUBURBS
Manufacturing Job Density Heat Map — Transportation & Industrial Analysis
Euclid
Bedford Heights
Solon
Brook Park
Independence
N
0
2
4
4
6 miles
MANUFACTURING JOB DENSITY
Very High (Red)
900+ Jobs/km²
High (Yellow/Orange)
500–900 Jobs/km²
Moderate (Orange)
200–500 Jobs/km²
Low (Light Blue)
50–200 Jobs/km²
Very Low (Cool Blue)
<50 Jobs/km²
Heat density derived from estimated manufacturing employment clusters, 2024
Base map: Cuyahoga County highway network. Highways: I-90 (Lake Erie corridor), I-271 (Outerbelt East), I-480 (Outer Belt South). Heat areas coincide with industrial parks in Solon, Euclid, Bedford Heights, Brook Park, Independence.

Proposed Solution: Southgate Transit Hub - Full Math

1) Scoring Formula:

Score = (0.6 × Population within 2mi + 0.4 × Jobs within 15mi) / (Avg Manhattan Distance + 1)

⚖ Weights: **60% equity • 40% jobs**

2) Manhattan Distance Formula:

|Δlat| × 69 + |Δlon| × 69 × cos(avg lat)

Example calculation for Southgate → Solon:

- Δlat 0.026° × 69 = 1.79 **mi**
- Δlon 0.12° × 69 × **cos(41.4°) = 6.21 mi**
- Total **= 1.79 + 6.21 = 8.00 mi**

3) Hub Distance Summary (Excluding Bedford) — Average of 3 Nearest = 6.10 mi

Hub	Distance	Est. Travel Time
• Solon	8.00 mi	~20 min
• Euclid	14.07 mi	~32 min
✓ Independence	6.62 mi	~16 min
• Brook Park	9.56 mi	~23 mi

Average of 3 nearest hubs (Solon, Independence, Brook Park) = 6.10 mi

4) Last-Mile Corrected:

3 mph = 20 min/mile

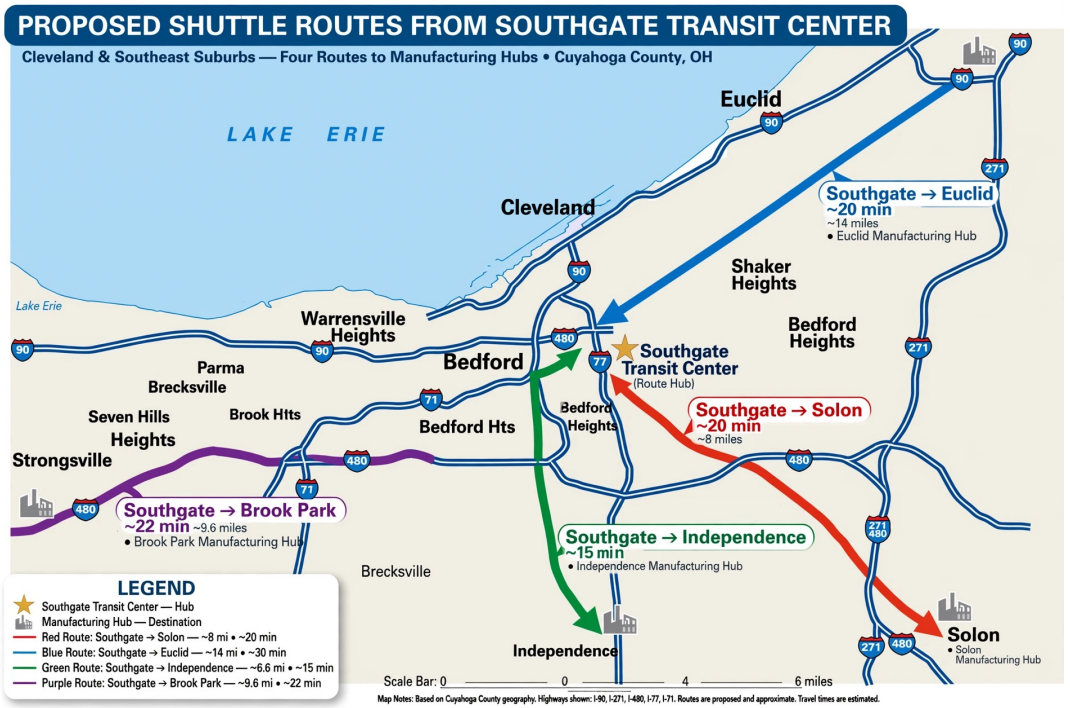
Hana	0.3 mi = 6 min
Swagelok	0.6 mi = 12 min
Nestle	1.1 mi = 22 min

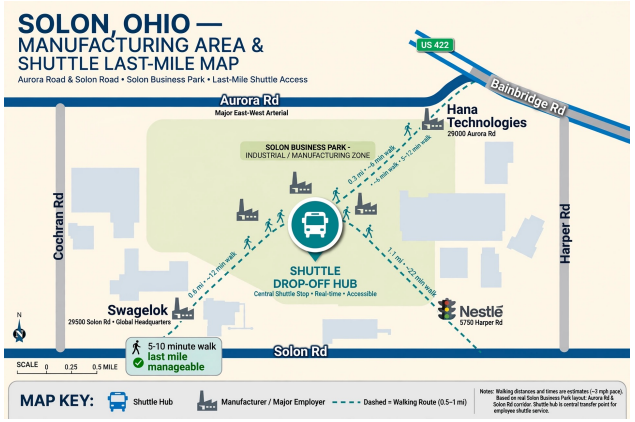
5) Final Score for Southgate

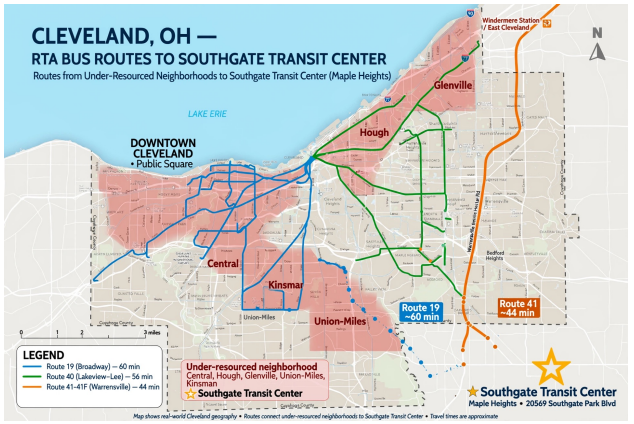
(0.6 × 4,656 + 0.4 × 25,945) (6.10 + 1) = 2,157

Result: 2,157 — Strong viability score

Analysis uses 2-mile population and 15-mile jobs for demand; Manhattan distance for realistic urban routing; 3 mph walking assumed for last-mile calculations


PROPOSED SHUTTLE ROUTES FROM SOUTHGATE TRANSIT CENTER
Cleveland & Southeast Suburbs — Four Routes to Manufacturing Hubs • Cuyahoga County, OH
LAKE ERIE
Lake Erie
Euclid
Cleveland
Shaker Heights
Warrensville Heights
Bedford
Bedford Heights
Parma
Brecksville
Seven Hills
Brook Hlts
Bedford Hts
Heights
Strongsville
Brecksville
Independence
Solon
• Solon Manufacturing Hub
Southgate Transit Center
(Route Hub)
Southgate → Euclid
~20 min
~14 miles
• Euclid Manufacturing Hub
Southgate → Solon
~20 min
~8 miles
Southgate → Brook Park
~22 min ~9.6 miles
• Brook Park Manufacturing Hub
Southgate → Independence
~15 min
• Independence Manufacturing Hub
LEGEND
Southgate Transit Center — Hub
Manufacturing Hub — Destination
Red Route: Southgate → Solon — ~8 mi • ~20 min
Blue Route: Southgate → Euclid — ~14 mi • ~30 min
Green Route: Southgate → Independence — ~6.6 mi • ~15 min
Purple Route: Southgate → Brook Park — ~9.6 mi • ~22 min
Scale Bar: 0 0 4 6 miles
Map Notes: Based on Cuyahoga County geography. Highways shown: I-90, I-271, I-480, I-77, I-71. Routes are proposed and approximate. Travel times are estimated.


SOLON, OHIO —
MANUFACTURING AREA &
SHUTTLE LAST-MILE MAP
Aurora Road & Solon Road • Solon Business Park • Last-Mile Shuttle Access
US 422
Bainbridge Rd
Aurora Rd
Major East-West Arterial
Hana Technologies
29000 Aurora Rd
SOLON BUSINESS PARK -
INDUSTRIAL / MANUFACTURING ZONE
Cochran Rd
Harper Rd
SHUTTLE
DROP-OFF HUB
Central Shuttle Stop • Real-time • Accessible
Swagelok
29500 Solon Rd • Global Headquarters
Nestlé
5790 Harper Rd
Solon Rd
5-10 minute walk
last mile
manageable
SCALE 0 0.25 0.5 MILE
MAP KEY:
Shuttle Hub
Manufacturer / Major Employer
Dashed = Walking Route (0.5–1 mi)


CLEVELAND, OH —
RTA BUS ROUTES TO SOUTHGATE TRANSIT CENTER
Routes from Under-Resourced Neighborhoods to Southgate Transit Center (Maple Heights)
LAKE ERIE
DOWNTOWN
CLEVELAND
• Public Square
Glenville
Hough
Central
Kinsman
Union-Miles
Route 19
~60 min
Route 41
~44 min
LEGEND
Route 19 (Broadway) — 60 min
Route 40 (Lakeview–Lee) — 56 min
Route 41-41F (Warrensville) — 44 min
Under-resourced neighborhood
Central, Hough, Glenville, Union-Miles, Kinsman
Southgate Transit Center
Southgate Transit Center
Maple Heights • 20569 Southgate Park Blvd
Map shows real-world Cleveland geography • Routes connect under-resourced neighborhoods to Southgate Transit Center • Travel times are approximate

SUGGESTIONS · 3 OF 3

First Shift

WHAT IT IS

A "Glassdoor" for first jobs. Young workers rate the employers they've worked for, so the the next worker sees what a job is really like before taking it.

HOW IT WORKS

Rate each employer on five things that make a first job survivable.
Each employer earns one "Worth Staying" score - the percent who'd refer a friend.
A searchable directory, filterable by "reachable by bus," carried through counselors.

DELIVERABLE

A working platform mockup: browse employers, read reviews, add a rating.

Open the live demo →

THE LOGIC

We measure young workers constantly but never the job.

05

SECTION 05

The Bottom Line

Reflections and closing out our experience.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Not a Story About Young People Who Won't Work

It's a story about stacked barriers, a front door employers haven't redesigned, and a generation whose strengths are real but underused.

01 **Shift employers from placement to partnership**

02 **Name the social determinants of work**

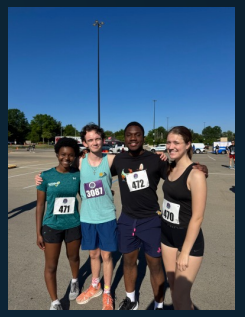
03 **Invest in mentorship, transit & normalized values**

04 **Start with who the young person is**









SECTION 06

Open Discussion

Thank you to everyone who shared their time, expertise, and stories with us. We'd love your reactions, and to follow up on what's feasible.



